HOME SYSTEMS & SAFETY

Keeping the house safe and working: utility shutoffs, fire safety, alarms, and protecting the home before and after a disaster.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General preparedness information, not a substitute for professional training, local rules, manufacturer instructions or medical care. **Practice skills in safe conditions before you need them, and verify important information with current official sources.**

1. UTILITY SHUTOFFS

Find each shutoff now, in daylight, and show every adult and teenager in the house. Tag it, and keep the right tool next to it.

UTILITY	WHERE IT USUALLY IS	TURN IT OFF WHEN	KNOW THIS
Natural gas	At the gas meter, outside. The valve is on the pipe coming out of the ground.	You smell gas, hear a hissing or blowing sound, or officials tell you to.	Get everyone out **first**. Don't use light switches or phones inside. Once it's off, only the gas company should turn it back on.
Water	Where the main pipe enters the house (basement, crawlspace, garage) or at the meter by the street.	A pipe bursts, or officials say the water is contaminated (to keep bad water out of your pipes).	Many valves need a quarter turn; older gate valves turn several times. Test it once a year.
Electricity	The main breaker at the top of the electrical panel (or the main fuse block).	Wiring is damaged, there are sparks or a burning smell, or flooding is coming.	**Never** touch the panel if you're standing in water or it's wet. Call the power company or an electrician.

2. SMOKE AND CO ALARMS

- **Smoke alarms:** in every bedroom, outside each sleeping area, and on every level including the basement.
- Test monthly. Replace smoke alarms **every 10 years** (the date is on the back).
- Interconnected alarms (all sound when one does) give the most warning.
- **Carbon monoxide alarms:** outside each sleeping area and on every level, if you have any fuel-burning appliance, a fireplace or an attached garage.
- Replace CO alarms when the maker says (often 5 to 10 years).
- If a CO alarm sounds: get everyone outside to fresh air, then call 911.

3. FIRE EXTINGUISHERS: P.A.S.S.

1. **PULL** the pin.
2. **AIM** low, at the base of the fire.
3. **SQUEEZE** the lever slowly and evenly.
4. **SWEEP** side to side.

- Use an extinguisher only on a **small** fire that isn't spreading, with a clear way out behind you, after everyone is leaving and 911 is called.
- An ABC-rated extinguisher works on most household fires. Keep one on each level and in the kitchen.
- If in doubt, get out.

4. HOME FIRE ESCAPE PLAN

- Know **two ways out** of every room, usually a door and a window. Make sure windows open and screens come out.
- Pick a meeting spot outside, in front of the house (a tree, a mailbox).
- Practice a fire drill **twice a year**, once at night.
- Get out and stay out. Never go back inside for anything.
- Crawl low under smoke. Feel doors with the back of your hand before opening; if hot, use the other way out.
- Sleep with bedroom doors closed. A closed door slows fire and smoke.

5. PROTECT THE HOUSE

RISK	BEFORE IT HAPPENS
Frozen pipes	Insulate pipes in unheated areas. In hard freezes, let faucets drip and open cabinet doors under sinks. Know where the water shutoff is.
Flooding	Keep gutters and drains clear. Move valuables and important papers off the floor. A battery backup for the sump pump. Flood insurance is usually a separate policy, and often has a 30-day wait.
Wind	Trim dead branches. Secure or bring in outdoor furniture. Know how to cover windows.
Earthquake	Strap the water heater to the wall; anchor tall furniture and TVs; use closed latches on cabinets.
Wildfire	Clear dead plants, leaves and firewood within 5 feet of the house. Clean gutters and roofs.
Losses	Make a photo or video inventory of every room and keep it off-site or in the cloud. Review your insurance each year. *(DC-05)*

6. AFTER A DISASTER

- Enter only when officials say it's safe. Watch for downed power lines, gas smells, structural damage and animals.
- Take photos of all damage before you clean up, for insurance.
- Wear gloves, sturdy boots and an N95 mask when cleaning; throw out anything soaked by flood water that can't be disinfected.
- Have a licensed electrician check any wiring or appliances that got wet before you use them.

7. OUR HOUSE

ITEM	LOCATION	LAST CHECKED
Gas shutoff (and wrench)		
Water shutoff		
Electrical panel / main breaker		
Fire extinguishers		
Smoke / CO alarms (replace by)		
Outside meeting spot		

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. National Fire Protection Association: Smoke Alarms; Carbon Monoxide; Home Fire Escape Planning; Fire Extinguishers. nfpa.org
2. U.S. Fire Administration: Home Fire Safety. usfa.fema.gov
3. FEMA: Ready.gov: Home Safety; Floods; Earthquakes; Wildfires; Safety Guidelines (utilities). ready.gov
4. UL Solutions Fire Safety Research Institute: Close Before You Doze. closeyourdoor.org
5. National Flood Insurance Program. floodsmart.gov

IMPORTANT: Gas, water and electrical systems differ. Ask your utility companies how to shut off yours safely. This document reflects the sources above as of November 2026.